

Red Badge of Courage
Union soldiers take aim in a scene from the film of Stephen Crane's 1895 Civil War novel, *The Red Badge of Courage.* Rifled muskets and more effective cannon gave Civil War armies a greater rate and range of firepower than in earlier conflicts, and soldiers learned to take up defensive positions behind field fortifications and entrenchments.

THE AMERICAN CIVIL WAR, fought between the secessionist Confederacy and the northern Union forces from 1861 to 1865, was primarily a foot soldiers' war. Around 80 per cent of those who fought were infantry. Career soldiers were few and far between on the Union side below the highest levels of command. Men fresh to war learned how to fight the hard way – on campaign. The Union soldiers developed tenacity and endurance in the harsh conditions of a conflict that cost one in four of them their lives.

President Abraham Lincoln first called for volunteers to fight to defend the Union after the Confederate attack on Fort Sumter in April 1861. Initially men were invited to sign up for 90 days' service – the time optimistically considered sufficient to suppress the rebellion – but this was soon extended to a more realistic three years. As a torrent of war fever swept the northern states, the volume of volunteers far exceeded the number that could be taken on. Around 300,000 were recruited by the first winter of the war, but far more would-be soldiers had by then been turned away. Young men naively enthusiastic for the experience of battle were desperate to see action before the expected short conflict ended. Many felt a vague but powerful patriotic devotion to the integrity of the United States; very few were inspired by the notion of fighting against slavery.



Forage cap
The insignia on the cap denotes the 124th New York Infantry, a Union volunteer regiment.

AN EVOLVING ARMY

America's small regular army was only marginally involved in the creation of the Union forces. Most regiments were formed from scratch, set up by a prominent local citizen who would later be confirmed as the regiment's colonel. When enough volunteers had been attracted, they set up a regimental camp and elected officers and NCOs. In practice, higher ranks were filled by the colonel's appointees, but those aspiring to be junior officers had to canvas for votes from the men they would then command. Whether appointed or elected, the officers rarely had military experience, and neither did their men. Some of the first recruits were members of local militias, but even these were no more than civilians who had enjoyed meeting up to parade in uniform.

Provision of uniforms and equipment was chaotic, depending upon local initiative as federal organization failed to cope. Regiments selected their own outfits, so the Union army first entered combat decked out in a wide range of uniforms, including Zouaves attired in a flamboyant imitation of French African troops, complete with a fez. After skimpy training, these diversely clad soldiers were carried by train to camps near the war front. Not surprisingly, their initial performance was mixed, courage only partly compensating for lack of skill, experience, and leadership. Defeat at Bull Run (Manassas) in July 1861 shocked the North into building a more professional-style army for a longer war.



SPRINGFIELD MODEL 1861